

AUSTIN
RAY BOUSE
SOMETHING
UNDER THE
BED

A Mrs. Macabre Story.

Something Under The Bed: A Mrs. Macabre Story

The Mrs. Macabre Chronicles

Austin Bouse

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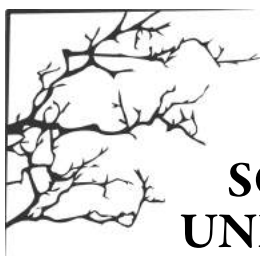
SOMETHING UNDER THE BED: A MRS. MACABRE STORY

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SOMETHING UNDER THE BED

Kerry Maguire had a secret. Now, it is fairly common for people to have secrets. Especially if you are eleven. Though it may be uncomfortable for your parents, having secrets is an essential part of childhood. Whether it be peeking at an unwrapped present, stealing something that one shouldn't have, or climbing a tree that an adult told you specifically *not* to, you have kept a secret at one point in time in your life. And you may have more when you grow up. Kerry wasn't entirely someone who kept secrets because she was not one to look for secrets to keep. She was not an adventurous girl by nature. In fact, she was known for being quite scared of most things. If a bee were to fly near her, she would quickly dodge out of the way as if it were on a mission to attack her specifically. She would never jump off of the diving board at a pool because she was afraid of heights, and the thought of hitting her head at the bottom was too terrible a thing for her to consider. She would even be cautious of taking *two* pain pills instead of one, just in case an overdose were to occur. Kerry didn't have many secrets, which made *this* secret especially large. It was a secret that had kept her up at night for weeks now. A secret that she would not dare tell her friends or teachers about. A secret too terrifying to say in pleasant company: Kerry Maguire knew that there was something under her bed.

You may be under the impression that she was mistaken. You may have heard that it is *highly* unlikely that there was something under her bed. You might have even conducted your own investigation and looked under your own bed to only find a box filled with old toys or the occasional dust bunny. But Kerry didn't *think* that there was something under her bed, she *knew* that there was something under her bed. It first began on a Friday. She had turned out the light and rested her head against her pillow when she heard a strange, low groaning sound. At first she had thought it might have been her house, for her walls would creak and her roof would rumble from the running of squirrels from time to time. But she soon realized that this was not the typical groaning that she was accustomed to. No, this groaning sounded organic, almost animal-like in its nature. It reminded her of when one of her neighbors' mean dog would growl at her from next door. A growl that started out low and quiet, a growl of warning. It was a sound that she did not take lightly.

She shifted to her side, hoping that it was just the mattress being fussy. But the growling continued. She held her stomach, thinking that perhaps it was something she had eaten. But it did not rumble. She quickly grabbed her pillow and folded it around her head, covering her ears. But even through the muffled fabric of the cushion, she could still hear it in a low steady drone. Kerry took off the pillow and looked around the room, unsure of what to do. She had tried every resource that she had at her disposal and nothing worked. It seemed that the best course of action was to wake her parents. Upset with her as they may be, they would soon realize that getting them up at this hour would be worth taking care of whatever lurked underneath her bed.

She whipped off the covers and, very gently, placed her feet on the floor. As her bare feet touched the smooth, cold, wood paneling, the growling grew even more aggressive and even more vicious than before. The growl had turned into a snarl, and she could now hear the thing under the bed breathing heavily, like an old locomotive train or a car engine roaring to life. It sounded as if the thing was preparing to charge out from under her bed. At that moment, Kerry decided to get a head start, and bolted out of her room. “*Mom!*” She screamed as she ran out and down the hallway. “*Dad! Help!*” She reached the door to her parents’ room and opened it. They had already turned on their lamp on the bedside table when she entered.

“What is it?” Her mother said, jolting out of bed. “What’s wrong?”

“Is everything okay, honey?” Her father asked, fumbling with his glasses.

“There’s-there’s something in my room!” Kerry said, out of breath.

“Your room?” Her mother glanced at her father.

“Yeah, under my bed!” She said with the same terror that one might use when alerting to someone that their house was on fire. But her parents did not share that same fear. In fact, they look relieved. They each breathed out a sigh of relief, her father fell back onto the bed and laughed. It confused her, yes, but it did not surprise her. Adults had a way of reacting to children, especially their own, in strange ways. She had been told many times that she had been silly or- what was the word that they had used?- *overdramatic* for being afraid of this thing or that. But she was certain that such a concern as something alive under her bed would cause then *some* alarm.

“Oh, sweetie,” her mother came to her, smiling, “there’s nothing under your bed.”

“Yes there is,” Kerry said with conviction. “I heard it,” her mother was using the same smile and the same tone that she had used whenever she was not taking her seriously. Kerry never liked it.

“Do you want me to look at it with you?”

YES! She wanted to cry out, but she could only nod.

“Okay, then,” her mother looked at her father, who yawned and took off his glasses. She took her hand and followed her out of the room.

Kerry dragged her down the hallway as quickly as she could, eager to show her proof of what terrorized her, but also afraid of what the thing would do to her mother if she got too close to it.

“It’s under there!” She pointed to the scene of the crime as her mother flipped on the light switch.

“Let’s see here. . .” her mother knelt down on the side of the bed and looked under it. She stared for a moment in silence. “Oh,” she finally said. “Oh. My. Gosh.”

“See?” Kerry said from behind her. “I told you there was something there!”

“I’ve been looking all over for this thing,” she turned around, holding one of her red heels, the same one her daughter had tried on while she was out of the house and forgot to return. One of Kerry’s few minor secrets.

“No,” Kerry slapped the front of her own face with her palm. “I’m telling you, Mom, I *heard* something.”

“Was it a nightmare? Sometimes I have nightmares and it feels like I’m awake.”

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"I was awake," Kerry said as if she had just asked her if fish swim in the ocean. "It was a growling sound and it was coming from right under *there*," she jabbed a finger towards the bed like a judge to the guilty.

"Well," her mother sighed, "if it happens again, I'll look again. Okay?" She kissed her on the forehead. "Night."

"Night," Kerry mumbled as her mom got up and left, shutting off the lights behind her. She sighed and got back into bed. Contrary to what her mother said, it was not a question of whether *if* the thing under her bed would return, but *when*. Kerry slept soundly for the rest of the night, only speaking of it briefly the next morning with her parents. Then it came back the next night.

And the next night.

And the next night.

The thing under her bed returned and growled at her in the dark. She was certain that if she were to tell her mom, one of two things would happen. Either, she would finally see the thing under the bed or she would not, and then get annoyed with her for waking her up to check on something that supposedly was not there. She had thought that the former would be nice, to be proven right was something she was not ashamed of liking, but she then realized that the latter outweighed the brief moment of satisfaction. It was not uncommon for her parents to be annoyed with her when she was afraid of something. They could lose their patients quickly and she did not like it when they would make a face at her as if they just tasted something sour or when they told her to get over it. So, she hoped the thing under the bed would eventually leave.

But it never did. It kept her up night after night for weeks on end.

Finally, she had had enough. If you were to go without sleeping for as long as she had, you would most likely face anything if it meant getting some shut eye. She flung back the covers and stared at the edge of the bed, then planted her feet onto the wood. She then gently crouched down with her head turned in the other direction, so that she wouldn't have to face the thing until she was ready. She waited for a moment and then turned her head.

The Thing was surrounded by darkness. She could not tell where the Thing began and where it ended, all she could see were two glowing red eyes staring at her above a set of razor sharp teeth. Kerry stayed as still as she possibly could, so still in fact, that if it weren't for her breathing you would think she was a wax statue of a little girl instead of a real one. She had read somewhere that some animals see are based on movement, and she hoped that was the case for this particular nocturnal creature. But that theory was soon proven incorrect, for even before she could even complete such a thought, the Thing grabbed her. Cold black paws gripped her wrists and pulled her into the dark before she had time to scream.

A gasp escaped her mouth as she was yanked into someplace unknowable. The red eyes of the creature were the only lights that she saw in the inky blackness. Her hands and knees were no longer dragging across the wood of her bedroom floor, but through dry leaves and dirt. She fell onto the ground, another gasp coming out of her lips as her jaw hit the dirt. She rubbed it and looked around. She was still in total darkness, but this felt different than the one that she had just traveled through. This

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felt like some type of inclosure, a space that had walls and a ceiling, but no lights that she was aware of. Kerry moved her hands about and flinched as she touched damp rocky walls. She listened and heard the faint trickle of water coming out of a crevice far away. She grabbed her shoulders as a steady gust of cold wind blew against her. She realized that she was now sitting in a cave.

“Hello?” She asked aloud, but the echo of her voice was the only thing that answered back. “Is- is anyone there?” She asked, hoping someone, *anyone* would return her query. The reply that came back was one that she had not been hoping for. Light shined in the cave, but not a welcoming one. It was the same scarlet glow that she saw from underneath her bed, however this time the eyes had multiplied. Pair upon pair of glowing eyes shone around her. As her own eyes adjusted to it, she saw the Thing and its siblings in all their horrible glory. They each had the same set of white fangs that the Thing carried, but she now saw that the eyes and jaws were attached to bodies of black fur. No, not fur, smoke. Black smoke took the forms of hound-like animals, they flanked around her on all fours, ears turned back with the stiffness of a wolf or a fox. Their growls sang to her in a chorus of terror. Each one began to bark at her in animal voices that she could not recognize. They were neither canine, feline, bird, or ape, but something else entirely alien to her ears.

“*Help!*” She screamed as loud as she could and ran, but she only reached a few steps until she fell to the ground once more. She spun around and saw that one of the monsters had clutched the fabric of her pajama pants with its teeth and was dragging her deeper into the cave. “*Someone, please!*” She screamed as she was being dragged further and further down the dark, cold corridor. “*Help!*” Tears streamed down her face as she gazed upon the

army of beats escorting her, white fangs smiling at her, possibly out of hunger. *"HELP!"*

An enormous white light filled the cave. Kerry covered her eyes with one of her arms, even with her eyes shut tight she could see the dim luminescence of the light. She heard whimpering and crying from the monsters all around her and felt the pull of her pajama pants leave.

"Take my hand," she heard a woman's voice say, but she still did not open her eyes. Everything was too scary, too dangerous for her to trust such a request. "It's okay," the voice said. "My magic scared them off," the voice sounded kind and warm, the same tone that her mother would use when trying to calm her down when she was crying. Kerry slowly moved her arm and opened her eyes.

The white light was slowly fading and balls of different colors swam in front of her face, like it did after seeing a camera flash. It took her a moment to realize who was standing in front of her, but when the moment passed, she was filled with even more questions than before. The woman in front of her reminded her of Mary Poppins, but weirder. She was dressed entirely in black to the point her own dark hair seemed to blend in with the hat she was wearing. Her skin was the color of chalk and she held a broom with a raven's skull that sat on top of it.

"They're gone," the woman said, her black lips smiling in a way that did not frighten her. "For now, at least."

Kerry took her pale hand and stood herself up. "Thank you," she said in a small voice. "Who are you?"

"My name," the woman said, "is Mrs. Lenore Macabre, witch for hire," she took off her hat and bowed to her. "And you are?"

"K-Kerry," she stuttered, taken aback by such a theatrical gesture. "Kerry Maguire

"Oh, I do love meeting strangers," Mrs. Macabre smiled at her. "Especially *strange* strangers. Tell me, Kerry, are you strange?"

"My grandma thinks so."

"That's good enough for me. Come, Kerry, you *must* be in need of help," Mrs. Macabre grabbed her hand and lead her out of the cave. They went scurrying through the darkness until Kerry could see the faintest hint of gray light up ahead. The mouth of the cave grew wider and wider until they finally reached the opening. The draft that she had felt from inside became even more apparent out in the open, she was surrounded by a forest of trees with a gray sky above her that gave her a chilly feeling that she felt before an Autumn rainstorm. This magical world was not as inviting and warm as the ones that she read in books. It felt dreary instead of dreamy.

"Kerry," Mrs. Macabre smiled at her, "meet my dear friend, Jack Lantern!" She had been so distracted by her surroundings that she failed to notice the person standing in front of her. The man was a walking, talking scarecrow. His head was not made of a burlap sack or cloth like she had seen in corn fields, but a pumpkin. She saw the orange-yellow glow of a candle burning through the holes of his eyes and the jagged saw-like opening that was his mouth.

"Pleased to meet you!" Jack Lantern said happily, his mouth did not move, but the candle in his head flickered with every word that he spoke.

She cried out in fear and fell down. "Get back!" She said as she crawled backwards away from him. "Don't hurt me!"

“Why, he’s not going to hurt you, my dear,” Mr. Macabre said gently, though with a tinge of bewilderment as if she had been afraid of an ant. “Jack would never intentionally hurt *anyone*.”

“Oh, I’ve done it!” Jack said, embarrassed. “The first time I’ve scared someone and it was a potential friend!” He covered his face with his hands and the candle blushed.

“But he’s- he’s a *monster*,” Kerry said, confused.

“Just because he is a monster doesn’t mean he’s not kind,” Mrs. Macabre shook her head. “Oh, my, this is going to be harder than I thought. Apologies, my child, since you said you were strange I thought that what you meant was that you were fond of. . . of. . .” She tried to think of the words, but they escaped her.

“Scary stuff?”

“Yes! Scary stuff! The children that come here from other worlds usually *love* scary things. But, for some reason, you don’t.”

“I didn’t *mean* to be here,” Kerry got back up and wiped the dirt off of her pajamas. “I was dragged here by one of those things,” she cocked a thumb to the cave behind her.

“Ah, that explains it, then. Bed Beasts are quite aggressive with their prey.”

“Bed Beasts?”

“Yes. Tricky things they are. They have a knack for building nests under beds. It must have created a portal between this one and your world. Did you stare at it, by any chance?”

“I was afraid to at first, but. . . I had to look at it.” Kerry’s head dipped slightly with shame.

“There’s no need to feel bad, my dear,” Mrs. Macabre reassured her. “It’s quite natural to want to look at something dangerous,” she smiled. “We should probably return to my home. It’s

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getting late and those Bed Beasts will realize that my sunlight charm wasn't real."

"What is this place?" Kerry asked as she followed them through the forest.

"The Hallowland," Mrs. Macabre replied. "The birthplace of monsters and all things spooky! Where are you from?"

"Waxahachie," Kerry said, thinking it wasn't nearly as weird as this place.

"Whacks-A-Hatchet?" Jack shuddered. "I thought you said you didn't like scary things?"

"No, *Waxahachie*, my dear, Jack," Mrs. Macabre chuckled. "It's in the world the Gracey twins are from."

"Oh. Are you friends with Jane and Catie?" Jack asked her.

"Who?"

"Here we are!" Mrs. Macabre exclaimed before the scarecrow had time to answer. "Home sweet home!" What stood in front of her was without a doubt the creepiest house she had ever seen. It was shaped like a black coffin, windows glowing with eerie light dotted the front of it here and there. The mist that surrounded it reminded her of one of her neighbors who would decorate their house with elaborate effects every Halloween. Whenever she had been out trick- or -treating, she was careful to avoid that particular house. She did not care how good the candy was, the fog and animatronic vampire outside the front yard was far too scary for her. "What do you think of it?"

"It's... disturbing?" Kerry said, attempting to be both honest and polite at the same time.

"Why thank you, darling!" Mrs. Macabre sparkled. "Just wait till you see the rest!" Mrs. Macabre pulled out a key from her dress pocket and went up the front stairs of the house.

Kerry sighed. Though she was grateful that Mrs. Macabre saved her, she had grown weary of how dark and morbid everything was. Out of all the magical lands she could have gone to, she *had* to get stuck in Monster World. Whatever happened to Cotton Candy Land or something more pleasant? She dutifully marched up the steps, the wood creaking under her feet

as her and Jack got closer to the front door. Mrs. Macabre opened it and they walked inside. The interior of the house was so different from its exterior that it nearly made Kerry collapse from vertigo. They were standing in foyer filled with various books, statues, bones, and other curious mementos lying about. But what stunned her was how big it was. Following a spiral staircase that began at the foot of the foyer, her eyes moved up, and up, and up, and up, until she could just barely make out the ceiling above her. From the forest, the house appeared to be no higher than three stories tall. But inside? It was about three hundred.

"Whoa," she said with her eyes wide and her mouth hanging open.

"Impressive, isn't it?" Mrs. Macabre said, placing her broom in the stand next to the door. "I still need a map from time to time to find the linen closet," she walked into the small kitchen off to the side. "Let me fix you something. Traveling between worlds can be exhausting."

Kerry and Jack followed her into the room. She was surprised by how cozy it was compared to the spooky aesthetic that surrounded her. Save for the cauldron, it was quite similar to her grandparents' kitchen. Mrs. Macabre snapped her fingers and one of the cupboards opened, a glass flew out of it and she caught it with free hand, opening the ice box with the other. She pulled

out a glass bottle filled with orange liquid and placed it on the table where she sat.

"Oh, I like orange juice!" Kerry said, relieved that it was something normal for a change.

"Orange juice?" Mrs. Macabre said, taken aback. "My dear, that's toad juice. Essential vitamins for any child of the Hallow-land."

Kerry stopped drinking and nearly spat it out. She didn't know what was worse, the fact that she was drinking something as awfully named as toad juice or that she secretly liked it. The drink was sweet, but also had a tinge of sourness that almost made her giggle. She swallowed it and politely said, "Thank you."

"You're quite welcome," Mrs. Macabre took the glass to the sink. "Tell us, Kerry, what gave you the courage to face such a dangerous animal as a Bed Beast?"

"Well, I wouldn't call it courage," she said sheepishly. "I'm usually pretty scared of stuff like that, but it was keeping me awake for so long that I just- I *had* to look."

"Sounds courageous to me."

"You're the first one to say that. I'm scared of everything. I'm sure it drives my parents and friends crazy."

"I'm always scared too," Jack said. "But those Gracey girls that we mentioned before taught me it was okay to be that way."

"Really?" Kerry asked in disbelief. "What do you mean?"

"Well, they told me that since they've never seen a scarecrow that was afraid of everything, being afraid is what made me unique. All my life I had told myself that I was a coward, that I was too full of fear and that I was a failure. I mean, the whole reason why I was exiled from the fields in the first place was that I just couldn't be scary. But now, I feel different about it. Thanks

to those two little girls, I'm proud to be afraid!" He puffed up his chest and the inside of his head glowed brightly. "I am Jack Lantern, The Scared Scarecrow!" He boomed, or as loud as his gentle voice could make, in a theatrical tone.

Kerry laughed and applauded at Jack's proclamation, but his point swam around in her mind like a happy fish. Perhaps it *was* okay to be afraid of so many things as she was. Perhaps it wasn't quite as much of a burden on others as she thought, but something that she was projecting onto *them* because of how terrible she had felt about it. Maybe being afraid wasn't all that made up the person that was Kerry Maguire, just a small piece of it.

"I don't mean to alarm anyone," Mrs. Macabre said, peeking out the window of the kitchen. "But it appears that we have some company."

Kerry and Jack got up from the table and went to the window. With Jack holding her up, Kerry saw something that made her gasp. Through the dusty pane of glass, she saw a horde of glowing red eyes staring back at her. They moved through the forest as swiftly as they had done in the cave. Their smokey bodies blending in with the night sky. "How did they find me?" Kerry asked.

"They must have tracked your scent," Mrs. Macabre said, staring out the window. "Their sight is based on darkness, so even if they do get in here, they'll be partially blind. I suggest the two of you hide."

"But where? This place is *huge*!"

"Exactly," Mrs. Macabre locked eyes with her. "There are rooms everywhere. Which means it will be harder for them to find *you*."

“Come on, Kerry,” Jack said. “If Mrs. Macabre tells you to do something, you’d better do it.” He set her down and grabbed her hand, running into the foyer. Mrs. Macabre came out and took out her broom from the stand.

“What about you?” She asked as Jack tugged her away.

“I’ll be fine,” Mrs. Macabre gripped her broom. “I’ve dealt with far worse than a few Bed Beasts.” She smiled and got into a stance, holding the broom like a sword, in front of the door. Kerry could see it shake and hear the sound of the Bed Beasts snarling and scratching against the wood.

“Come on! Let’s hide in here!” He opened the door nearest to them and shut it as quickly as he could.

“Where are we?” she asked in the darkness.

“The closet,” he said, flicking a switch next to the door. The light bulbs above them turned on and she saw that the closet that they were standing in was the biggest she had ever been in her entire life. Row after row of brooms, sponges, rags, glass bottles of cleaning fluid, and so on lined the room.

“Is everything bigger on the inside here?” She asked.

“Yes,” he replied. “Trust me, we’re lucky to be in here. Be glad we’re not in the Mummy Room,” he shuddered at the thought of it.

Through the door of the closet, they heard the front door shatter into pieces. “*I loved that door!*” They heard Mrs. Macabre shouting. The Bed Beasts roared and barked at her. They could hear the sounds of things crashing against the foyer floor. At one point Kerry could have sworn she heard the clashing of steel, like a sword fight.

“What’s going on out there?” She asked, pressing her ear against the door.

“Something dangerous, I bet,” Jack said. “But that broom of hers can practically turn into anything. It’s the source of her magical powers.”

The door shook violently and they both ran back. As it continued to shake, they heard the clawing of the Beast behind it, trying to get in. They heard the same snarling that they had heard moments ago, but this time it was much closer, breathing underneath the frame, blowing warm steam into the closet. Kerry and Jack moved back, and back, and back until they hit the wall of the closet, startling them both. The wood finally broke into splinters as the Beast entered the room. Its pitch-black paws slowly made its way forward, its head moving this way and that, trying to feel out the space that it was in. Tendrils came flying out of its back, hitting the lights above it and breaking them.

All that could be seen within the darkness was the faint glow of Jack’s head and the redness of the Beast’s eyes as it came closer and closer. Its jaws were open, ready to attack its prey.



“Please don’t eat us!” Jack pleaded with the Beast and his head grew brighter than Kerry had ever seen it. Flames licked around his eyes and mouth in terror. The Beast moved back. The two of them looked at one another.

“Your fire,” Kerry smiled. “I think the brightness is making it act like that. Try to make it brighter.” Jack made a sound like taking a huge breath and the flames grew higher and brighter. The Beast retreated farther. “Keep going!” Kerry encouraged him.

Jack did his track again and again until the Beast ran to a corner of the room. "We did it!" Kerry high-fived him.

"Thank goodness," Jack exhaled, "if I had to do that any longer, I could've gone up like a barn!"

Kerry went to the corner to see what had happened to the monster. Jack followed and she soon saw something that puzzled her. The Beast who, moments before, was ready to devour them, was curled up in a corner, shaking.

"What's wrong with it?" The scarecrow asked.

"I think it's-" Kerry started. "I think it's *afraid*," She moved closer towards it.

"What are you doing?" Jack pulled her arm, "It'll kill you!"

But Kerry gently took her hand away from his. She bent down and slowly eased up to it. "Come here," she said tenderly. "I'm not going hurt you." The Beast whimpered and tried to retreat further into the corner and could only hit a wall. "It's okay," she continued. "I promise." The Beast very slowly moved away from the corner and sniffed her hand. It bowed its head and allowed her to pet its fur, or the closest thing it had to fur. The black smoke felt smooth like velvet as it touched her fingers. "It was just scared," she said to Jack, who tilted his head. The Beast licked her on the face and she laughed as she felt the strange wetness hit her cheek.

They soon walked out of the closet with the Bed Beast guiding the way. When they walked out, the only thing that illuminated the foyer were the eyes of the Beast's family. The objects that had filled the room were now thrown all over it.

"Get back, you two!" Mrs. Macabre said, holding her broom which had now been turned into a sword. "It's too dangerous for.

. .” She looked at the Bed Beast next to them, who was standing quite calmly.

“It’s all right,” Kerry said. “All it needed was some trust,” the Bed Beast next to her gave a low howl, filled with tenderness and calm. Its family returned the howl and they all bowed their heads.

“They were after you because they were scared,” Mrs. Macabre said, looking around her in awe. “They thought you were invading their home, so they got angry and. . .” She smiled. “You are full of surprises, Ms. Maguire.”



THE THREE OF THEM RETURNED to the cave shortly thereafter along with the family of Bed Beasts escorting them. “Are you sure you want to leave just now?” Mrs. Macabre asked. “The Hallowland can be quite beautiful, if you give it a chance.”

“I’m sure it is,” Kerry laughed. “But I don’t think I’m meant to be here,” She looked over and saw Jack standing with his head hung low. “What’s the matter Jack?”

“Oh, nothing,” he sighed. “I just thought that since you and I were afraid of so many things that we could be friends.”

“Don’t be sad,” she went over to him. “I’m sure that there are plenty of people out there who are just as afraid of things as we are.”

“I suppose.”

“You did teach me something, though,” she whispered.

“What?” He asked, kneeling down to her.

“I’m not afraid to be afraid, anymore.”

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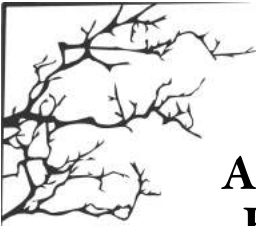
Jack's head glowed brighter. "That makes me feel better, then," he said and hugged her.

Kerry walked over to Mrs. Macabre. "I know we haven't known each other for very long," she said. "But you are, without a doubt, the strangest person I've ever met."

"That's very kind of you to say, my dear," Mrs. Macabre blushed. "You are quite strange, yourself. In your own way."

Kerry hugged her and then turned to the Bed Beast that she had comforted before. "Ready?" She asked. The Beast bowed its head and went towards the space that connected its world to hers. Kerry took one last look at the Hallowland, crouched down, and crawled along with the Beast.

The dirt floor underneath her hands and knees quickly turned into the familiar wood paneling of her bedroom. She could now see that the darkness of the cave had been replaced by the gray light of the moon as it shone through the window. She got herself up from the floor and looked around: Same old bedroom in her same old house. She looked back and saw that the portal was gone and she briefly thought that it could have been a dream, but the dirt that stained her palms was evidence otherwise. She crawled back into bed and covered herself with her sheets. Now, with nothing under her bed to be afraid of and no secret to keep, Kerry Maguire slept better than she had in weeks.



**AN EXCERPT
FROM MRS.
MACABRE. NOW
AVAILABLE IN
EBOOK AND
PAPERBACK.**

It was past midnight when the raven and the cat materialized from the dark. Materialized is the correct term, for if you had been outside at such a late hour or had peeked from your window, you would've seen the animals emerge from the darkness as if it were a curtain. Their black feathers and fur glistening in the street lamps. You would have also noticed how odd the pairing was. The raven was not flying from the cat, nor was the cat chasing after the raven. They were both moving as if they were on a stroll together, the raven hovering slightly above the cat.

Once they had exited from the night, they both stopped at the end of the street, with the raven landing next to the cat. They stood there for a moment, as if they were trying to figure out what to do next.

"So," the cat finally said to the raven, "we're here aren't we?"

"Patience, Elvira," the raven said to her companion. "We should wait first." The raven spoke with a voice that was deep, smooth, and confident. The voice of a woman who had done her fair share of waiting before.

"Wait for what?" Elvira said impatiently. She scratched her ear with her paw.

A bright light came from off to the side, a car was speeding right towards them. The raven flew with a caw and landed on the nearest light post. Elvira arched her back and hissed, her eyes filled with fear, the car honked, swerved, but hit her nonetheless.

"That," the raven said and flew down to her companion, her talons hitting the ground with a righteous click.

The cat's body lay limp for a moment, then there were the sounds of small cracks as her bones reformed inside herself. She blinked and got up. "Can't believe you made me waste a life on

one of those things,” Elvira shook her head. “Why do they have such *ugly* machines here?”

“Because they don’t have magic here, darling,” she sighed, tenderly. “How many lives do you have left now?”

“One,” Elvia grumbled.

“Oh,” The raven paused, embarrassed by how flippant she had been. “Then we’ll be more cautious from now on, won’t we?” She looked down the street, left and then right. “Now, I believe the coast is clear.”

The raven placed her wings in front of her and bowed her head into them. If you were to gaze once again from the window or the street, you would’ve been so shocked that you might have thought you were dreaming. Yes, two talking animals were alarming enough, but what was even more alarming was that the raven was growing. The bird grew to the height of an average adult, her wings wrapped around her body, her feathers swished as if hundreds of dresses were being unfurled together. The feet of the bird turned into heels with pointed toes. Her wings grew pale hands with black nails and her feathers became a black dress. The head of the bird had changed to a woman’s with skin the color of paper and hair and lips as dark as the night sky. She wore a small hat that had a black feather sticking out of it with a veil that draped on the side of her face. In her hand, she held a broom. The transformation was complete and there, standing next to the cat on an ordinary street, was Mrs. Macabre.

“Show off,” Elvira scoffed.

“Now, now, my dear,” Mrs. Macabre smiled, “there are plenty of people who can turn into animals, but not too many animals who can talk.”

“Let’s just get this over with,” the cat eyed her companion’s broom. “You might want to change that. I don’t believe people here are accustomed to walking with brooms down streets?”

Mrs. Macabre looked down at her broom. It was a beautifully ornate thing: Dirty blonde straw from the fear fields, a long black handle made of wood from a hemlock tree with symbols and hieroglyphics carved into it, a skull of a raven sat nicely at the top of it.

“Yes,” she placed a hand to her chin, “yes, I do suppose you are right,” there was a moment of silent contemplation, then she exclaimed, “I’ve got it!”

Mrs. Macabre stood next to her broom and began to twirl it with two fingers. It quickly took a life of its own and began to spin without her assistance. As it spun, the broom slowly changed, it’s straw disappeared and was replaced by large bat wings. The broom stopped spinning and it became apparent that there wasn’t any bat wings at all, but the canopy of a black umbrella.

“Better?” She asked.

“I believe so,” Elvira said, walking forward. “Now come on. If we don’t get back home soon, we’ll be stuck here till tomorrow night. You wouldn’t want to stay in the sun now would you?”

Mrs. Macabre shuddered at the thought. Where she and Elvira came from, they were never bothered by the cruel heat of an unforgiving sun. The closest their world came to daylight was a dreary overcast.

As they walked down the neighborhood street, Mrs. Macabre’s heels clacked against the asphalt like talons. She had hoped that the sound would not disturb any of the residents from their slumber or a bad case of insomnia. Though she had

visited this world countless times, she had never been pleased by how plain the houses were. They just sat there next to each other like perfect white squares in their perfectly manicured lawns, with their perfectly straight driveways. There were no jagged lines, dead flowers, or a hint of black to be found on any them. The houses didn't even *move*! How primitive. The only resemblance this world had to her own was the current darkness and a pleasant mist that hung faintly in the air. She smiled at how grim it felt .

"Do you see anything?" She asked the cat.

"Not particularly," Elvira said as they walked, staring at each house. "Or, at least not what we're looking for."

"I hope no one sees us" Mrs. Macabre said, annoyed. "If we run into another girl scout, I swear to Hades—"

"Wait," Elvira stopped dead in her tracks.

"Yes?" Mrs. Macabre perked up a bit.

Elvira nodded to her. They both walked towards a house, the damp grass squeaking under their feet as they quietly grew closer. A loud bark came from behind the fence next to the house, making them stop.

"Dogs," Elvira hissed, hair standing up. "Why do so many of them have to have dogs?"

"Patience, my sweet," Mrs. Macabre reassured her, "they can be easily distracted." She tilted her umbrella up and a piece of straw grew out of the tip of it. She held it between two fingers, gazing at it intensely. The bit of straw slowly turned into a white bone. She threw it over the fence and the dog stopped barking, the thumping of its paws could be heard running across the yard.

"Thanks," Elvira sighed.

"You're welcome," Mrs. Macabre smiled. "Where are they?"

“Up there,” Elvira tilted her head towards the second floor of the house. Another black window stared back at them like all the rest.

“Ah, yes,” Mrs. Macabre moved closer, almost to the front porch. “Come on up, then,” she gestured her shoulder to Elvira. The cat hopped on and sat next to her head, with both her hands on the handle of the umbrella, Mrs. Macabre flew upwards.

They reached the window and hovered in front of it. From the glow of the moonlight, Mrs. Macabre could see two beds occupied by two girls who looked almost exactly alike. Their room was decorated with fake spider webs and bats, posters of *The Nightmare Before Christmas* and other spooky films hung here and there. A collection of horror books were placed neatly on a shelf in the corner.

“Oh, I like them very much, indeed,” Mrs. Macabre whispered, “but do you think they require our assistance?”

Elvira’s eyes glowed the color of glow-in-the-dark paint, and stared at the children. “They would do well back home,” she said, distracted, as if she was looking for something.

Mrs. Macabre nodded in agreement.

“They are not liked by others,” she continued. “But that’s because they possess qualities that more. . . narrow minded folk do not see.”

“Is that a yes?”

“It is,” Elvira’s eyes returned to their normal, darker green shade.

“Wonderful then let us-” she gasped.

“What is it?” Elvira asked, she squinted in the window and saw, the clock on their nightstand, glowing with the same green

as her eyes had been just moments before: It was ten minutes till the hour was up.

"Blast!" Mrs. Macabre said, then quickly flew back down. Elvira jumped off and they went rushing off of the front lawn and into the street.

"I told you we should have left the manor earlier!. You're always so-" Elvira panted

"Oh, do shut up, darling," Mrs. Macabre said as her umbrella transformed into a broom again. They reached the black area from which they had entered.

Elvira had noticed her companion had stopped. "Well," she said impatiently, "come on, then!"

"You stay here," Mrs. Macabre said.

"What?" Elvira said, shocked.

"I need you to keep an eye on the children, dear," Mrs. Macabre said keeping her measured tone.

"Why?"

"Because we want to be certain that these are the *correct* children."

"But-"

"Would you care for me to jog your memory on what happened last time?" Mrs. Macabre's face was still as stone and her eyes were as sharp as knives. Elvira knew what that expression meant, she had seen it in her companion's darkest moments. It was an expression of utmost certainty.

"Yes," Elvira sighed. "You're right."

"Good kitty," Mrs. Macabre smiled and scratched Elvira behind her right ear, her favorite spot. "In the meantime, have some dinner," she removed another straw from her broom and tossed it up in the air. By the time it had hit the ground, it had trans-

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formed into a mouse. It squeaked at the sight of the cat and ran away.

Elvira glared at it with hungry eyes. "Thank you," she looked back up at Mrs. Macabre, who had taken her raven shape again. "But don't do this again."

"Nevermore," said the raven and she flew into the darkness.

"Hilarious," Elvira said and ran down the street, looking for the mouse.

About the Author

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Austin(they/them) is a writer living in central Texas. They have also written the novels *Mrs. Macabre* and *Never*. They have a form of cerebral palsy. They plan on keeping it that way.

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